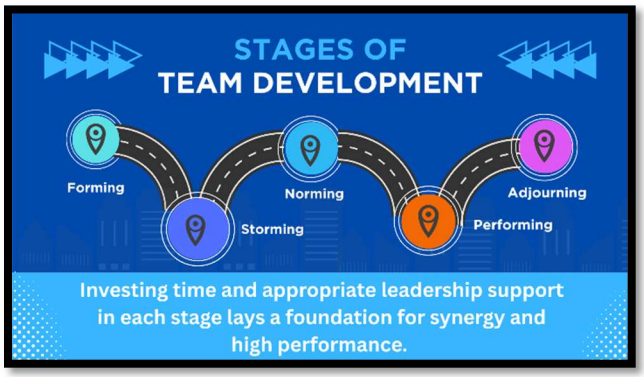
# Leadership Tool: Leading Teams Through the Different Stages

Leaders often find that bringing a group of individuals together and guiding them into a cohesive high-performing team is both a challenge and an art. One useful framework for understanding team development is Tuckman's model, which outlines five stages that teams typically progress through: Forming, Storming, Norming, Performing, and later Adjourning. First proposed by psychologist Bruce Tuckman in 1965 (with the fifth stage added in 1977), this model remains one of the most widely used in team development research and practice (Tuckman et al., 1977). At each stage, a team's behavior and needs change, and so should the leader's approach. By recognizing what *stage* a team is in, leaders can tailor their style and interventions to guide the team effectively through that phase.




Understanding Tuckman's stages isn't just academic – it has real practical value for leaders. Studies have shown that when team members and leaders understand these development stages, they can improve the team's effectiveness (Muscato, et al., 2023). In fact, teams that skip crucial early stages (for example, rushing past "forming") often find themselves stuck in conflict and unable to progress smoothly. In the following sections, we'll explore each of Tuckman's five stages and discuss the *best leadership practices* for that stage, based on scholarly insights and proven approaches. These best practices will help leaders navigate the journey from a newly formed team to a successful mission completion in an engaging and effective way.

## Forming – Laying the Foundations

The **Forming stage** is the team's infancy – a period of orientation and introduction. In this initial stage, team members are just coming together and often feel excited yet uncertain. Individuals tend to be polite, positive, and somewhat cautious as they figure out where they fit in. Roles and responsibilities are not yet clear, and members may be unsure about the team's norms or expectations. It's normal at this point for people to have many questions and mild anxiety about the group's purpose and their own place in it. Essentially, the team is *laying its foundation*: relationships are beginning to form and everyone is looking to understand the team's mission.

### *Leader's Role in Forming:*

At forming, the leader's influence is critical. Team members will look to the leader for guidance and clarity since they haven't established their own structure yet. A leader should take a proactive, facilitative role by providing structure and setting the tone. This means creating a welcoming environment for introductions and rapport-building. Encourage team members to get

to know one another – for instance, a leader might kick off with group introductions, icebreakers, or casual social time. These activities help break initial discomfort and start building trust. Research emphasizes that spending time on relationship-building at the outset is an important part of team development (Muscato, et al., 2023). Leaders should also communicate the "big picture" – clearly explain why the team exists, its goals, and each person's importance to that mission. Even if individual roles are not fully defined yet, team members should understand why they were invited onto the team and what the team as a whole aims to achieve. In practical terms, this could involve reviewing the team's charter or objectives together and fielding any questions.

Additionally, it's wise for the leader to establish initial ground rules and expectations for how the team will operate (e.g. meeting routines, communication norms). By providing this clarity and positive guidance during Forming, a leader lays down a strong foundation. In summary, the best practice for leaders in the forming stage is to be clear, inclusive, and structured: welcome the team, clarify its purpose, define some early guidelines, and start building trust among members (Muscato, et al., 2023). This investment in the Forming stage will pay off by preventing misunderstandings and "false starts" later. After all, teams that *don't* gel in the forming stage may struggle to move past conflicts in the next stage, so it's crucial for a leader to get this stage right.

## Storming – Navigating Conflict and Challenge

After a team has formed, it inevitably enters the **Storming stage**. In the Storming phase, the polite calm of forming gives way to turbulence: team members begin voicing differing ideas, personalities clash, and conflicts surface. As people feel a bit more comfortable, they may start to push against boundaries or become competitive. Tensions can arise over roles ("Who's in charge of what?"), goals, and working styles. It's common for members to become critical of each other or even challenge the leader's approach during storming (Kumar et al., 2014). This stage can be uncomfortable – members might experience frustration, stress, or concern that the team won't meet its objectives. However, in the view of team development experts, storming is a necessary and even healthy stage (Muscato, et al., 2023). It's during this period that the team addresses differences and settles into a realistic groove of working together. In other words, storming is about figuring out *how* the team will deal with disagreements and divergent viewpoints.

### *Leader's Role in Storming:*

In the storming phase, a leader's instinct might be to smooth over or suppress conflict, but best practices suggest a more nuanced approach: embrace and manage the conflict constructively. Conflict, when guided appropriately, can actually strengthen a team. It forces important issues into the open and, when resolved, increases mutual understanding. Rather than fearing conflict, leaders should normalize it. This means reassuring the team that disagreements are normal and distinguishing between *healthy conflict* (ideas and viewpoints clashing in productive debate) versus unhealthy conflict (personal attacks or destructive arguments) (Muscato, et al.,

2023). Leaders can set ground rules that disagreements should focus on ideas, not personalities, and model this behavior themselves by staying calm and respectful during disputes.

Practical best practices for a leader during Storming include active listening and mediation—ensuring everyone is heard and underlying issues are addressed. If discussions become unproductive or tense, leaders should step in to refocus the team on shared goals and, when needed, revisit goals or break tasks into smaller parts to reduce frustration. Constructive feedback is crucial: correct problems privately, praise positive conflict handling, and encourage the team to build conflict-resolution skills through simple decision-making protocols. Leaders should also address issues early, before they escalate, and bring conflicting parties together for open dialogue. Importantly, trust is built in this phase as teams navigate conflict successfully, making it vital for leaders to guide—not avoid—disagreements, setting the foundation for smoother collaboration ahead.

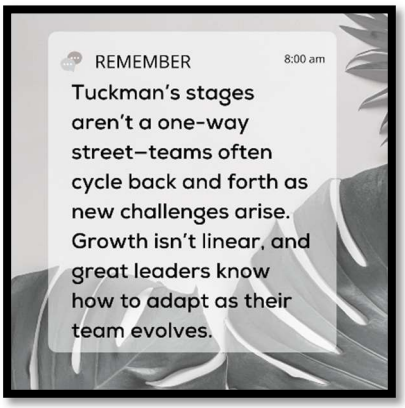
## Norming – Developing Cohesion and Trust

If a team successfully navigates the storming stage, it enters the **Norming stage**. In Norming, the chaos of conflict begins to subside, and a sense of order and cohesion emerges. Team members start to resolve their differences, establish agreements on norms and roles, and develop healthier working relationships. There is a noticeable shift: individuals understand and appreciate each other's strengths instead of focusing on flaws. Team "rules" or norms solidify in this phase – whether formally or informally, the group settles on how decisions are made, how communication flows, and who is responsible for what. Morale and trust typically increase now. Members feel more comfortable expressing real opinions, knowing others will listen. The team finds its "rhythm" or team flow, leading to improved collaboration. It's common at this stage to see engagement and confidence rise while stress levels fall. The group is well on its way to becoming a unified team rather than a collection of individuals.

**It's worth noting that teams aren't immune to setbacks – even in Norming, a new challenge or change can momentarily throw the team back into a bit of storming, but because they've learned conflict skills, they can handle it better.**

### *Leader's Role in Norming:*

During the norming stage, the leader's role begins to shift from director to facilitator/coach. Since the team has developed some self-sufficiency and harmony, a leader can step back a little compared to the earlier stages. However, *active leadership* is still needed to solidify and reinforce the positive dynamics forming. One best practice is for the leader to acknowledge and celebrate progress – both the team's achievements and individual contributions. Recognition goes a long way in this stage: it reinforces the behaviors and cooperation that got the team to norming. A leader might say in a meeting, "I want to acknowledge how far we've come – our last report was excellent, and that was a team effort. Also, thank you to Alice for stepping up to resolve the scheduling issue last week." Such recognition boosts morale and encourages continued collaboration.




Another key action is providing continual feedback and encouragement. The team has momentum now, and the leader should keep that momentum going. Regular check-ins on goals, along with positive feedback, help sustain performance. Importantly, the leader should monitor team dynamics quietly and step in only when necessary. In norming, minor conflicts or issues may still pop up, but ideally the team can resolve many of these on their own. A good leader trusts the team to handle small disagreements, intervening only if the conflict threatens to escalate or linger. This empowers team members and shows that the leader has confidence in their maturity. As one guide suggests, leaders at this stage should allow members to try solving problems themselves, but remain available as a safety net (Stein, n.d.). Furthermore, the leader should ensure everyone stays involved: no one should be feeling left out or underutilized. Sometimes in norming, a quieter member might start to fade into the background; the leader can engage that person by soliciting their input and assigning them meaningful responsibilities. Inclusivity strengthens the team's cohesion. Finally, the leader can encourage the team to codify some of its successful norms and processes. For example, if the team found a great way to run meetings during storming, the leader might formalize that as the standard meeting procedure going forward. By the end of Norming, a leader should see a more confident, cooperative team. The best practice here is to support and sustain the team's self-management: keep them on track through feedback and recognition but also give them room to grow.

## Performing – Reaching Optimal Performance

In the **Performing stage**, the team has hit its stride. This is often the most rewarding phase for both the team and its leader. By now, the group is high-functioning, productive, and unified. Team members know one another's strengths and work together seamlessly. There is a strong sense of trust and camaraderie; members feel comfortable to debate ideas openly without it turning personal, and they hold each other accountable for the results (Muscato, et al., 2023). Importantly, the team's focus is firmly on achieving its shared goals. With relationships and processes ironed out in earlier stages, the lion's share of energy can now go into accomplishing tasks efficiently and creatively. In a performing team, you might observe members proactively helping each other, adapting flexibly to new challenges, and perhaps even exceeding expectations. Conflict is rare, and when it occurs, it's dealt with constructively and quickly. Everyone is "in the zone," so to speak. Not all teams reach this stage, but those that do are often highly successful in their objectives and experience high morale. In practical terms, a performing team might complete projects ahead of schedule, innovate new solutions, or maintain high quality with minimal oversight.

### *Leader's Role in Performing:*

A common saying is that in a truly performing team, the leader can "get out of the way" – and indeed, the leader's role at this stage is the least hands-on of all the stages. The leader becomes more of a delegator, supporter, and monitor rather than a director. One best practice is to empower the team with autonomy. Since the team members are competent and aligned, a leader

should confidently delegate tasks and decision-making as appropriate, stepping in only for big decisions that the team can't handle alone or to provide resources. The leader is still paying attention to ensure things stay on track, but they are not micromanaging how the work is done. This can be a relief for leaders – it frees up time to focus on higher-level concerns or strategic planning while the team handles day-to-day execution.

Another critical role for the leader in performing is to maintain the team's focus and motivation. Even high-performing teams can lose momentum or get complacent, so the leader should continue to provide a clear vision of success and set stretch goals to keep the team challenged (but not overwhelmed). Regularly revisiting the team's mission or showing how their work contributes to organizational objectives can keep the fire burning. Also, the leader should be vigilant about protecting the team from external disruptions. At performing stage, one dysfunction could be outside interference or scope creep; a good leader serves as a buffer, shielding the team so they can concentrate on their work. Finally, celebrating accomplishments becomes even more important now: it not only rewards the team's hard work but also reinforces the behaviors that led to success. Recognition in this stage might shift to highlighting team achievements as well as continued individual praise for exceptional contributions (Muscato, et al., 2023).

## Adjourning – Celebrating Achievement and Providing Closure

The journey doesn't end with performing; eventually, teams face the **Adjourning stage**. Adjourning occurs when the team has completed its task or mission and is ready to disband or reorient to a new goal. In many project teams or short-term initiatives, this stage is inevitable – the team delivers the product or outcome, then members move on to other teams or projects. Even for standing teams, adjourning might come with a significant change like a reorganization or a key member leaving, effectively ending the team as it once was. This stage is often emotionally mixed: there's cause for celebration (the team accomplished its objectives) and sometimes sadness or nostalgia (people who bonded may feel a sense of loss separating from the team) (Muscato, et al., 2023). Team members might reflect on what went well and what could have been better, as part of the natural winding-down. In an ideal scenario, adjourning is a planned, positive experience – a time to acknowledge the team's journey and set the stage for future success, either for the individuals or any new teams that may form.

### *Leader's Role in Adjourning:*

The leader's responsibility in this final stage is to orchestrate a good ending. Just as a strong beginning (forming) is important, a thoughtful conclusion helps ensure that the team's work is recognized and that members feel a sense of closure. One best practice is to formally celebrate the team's achievements. This could involve holding a final meeting or event to showcase results, thanking each member for their contributions, and perhaps creating a summary of the team's accomplishments that can be shared with the wider organization. Recognition during

adjourning isn't just a feel-good exercise, it helps team members internalize the success and lessons of the project and leave on a high note (Muscato, et al., 2023). For example, a leader might present certificates of appreciation or write personalized notes to each team member highlighting what they did well. These gestures reinforce everyone's value and the significance of the team's work.

Another critical role for the leader is to facilitate reflection and knowledge transfer. Before everyone goes their separate ways, it's useful to discuss: *What did we learn? What should we do differently next time?* A leader can lead a brief retrospective, inviting honest feedback about the team's processes and outcomes. This conversation not only brings closure but also extracts lessons that team members carry into their next endeavors (and that the organization can use to improve future teams). It's also an opportunity for the leader to give final feedback and encourage each person's growth. Additionally, the leader should ensure any unfinished business is wrapped up: deliverables handed off, documentation completed, and any external stakeholders properly informed of the project's completion. Taking care of these details respects the work the team has done and upholds professional standards. In short, the leader acts as a facilitator of closure – celebrating successes, preserving learnings, and ensuring that each member feels a sense of accomplishment and appreciation as the team adjourns. This not only honors the team's journey but also boosts the likelihood that members will approach their next team experience with optimism and confidence.

## Conclusion

Tuckman's team development model offers leaders a practical roadmap for guiding teams through growth and change. By recognizing the stages—Forming, Storming, Norming, Performing, and Adjourning—leaders can adjust their approach to meet evolving team needs: offering direction in forming, coaching through conflict in storming, encouraging autonomy in norming, trusting performance in performing, and providing closure in adjourning. Research shows that this kind of adaptive leadership builds trust, promotes sustained success, and helps teams navigate setbacks effectively. While teams may not progress in a perfect sequence, leaders who flex their style at each stage create both high-performing and highly fulfilling teams. In leadership development, this reinforces a powerful truth: *how* you lead must evolve as your team evolves.

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